

ANI

it, raising concern that routine enrolment and updating were being displaced by SIR

DEFENCE: No legal requirement to conduct SSR and SIR together. Both are forms of revision under the Representation of People's Act, while continuous updating continues year-round. ECI points to four qualifying dates and claims 27.3 million voters in the 18-28 age group have been added since SIR began

CHARGE: 'Unmapped' and 'logical discrepancy' filters are opaque and can generate irrational or mechanical notices over small age gaps, spelling variations or changes in a woman's linkage from father to husband

DEFENCE: ECI says document list is not exhaustive; no voter will be deleted without a hearing

on September 23, voicing a difference of opinion with Justice Satish Chandra Sharma over a challenge to the 2023 law governing the appointment of ECs.

The three men at the centre of the storm are career bureaucrats who came to Nirvachan Sadan from other arms of government. Kumar, a 1988-batch IAS officer of the Kerala cadre and an IIT Kanpur alumnus, headed the Jammu and Kashmir division of the home ministry when Article 370 was revoked in 2019, and also served as Union secretary, cooperation. Sandhu, an officer of the same batch from the Uttarakhand cadre, is a doctor by training who went on to become Uttarakhand's chief secretary and chairman of the National Highways Authority of India. Joshi, a Haryana-cadre officer and IIT Roorkee alumnus with a doctorate from Geneva, was registrar general and census commissioner from 2019 to 2022 and later Haryana's chief secretary.

Taken together, the internal dissent recorded by the two ECs, the court battle over the process for appointing ECs and the commission's own defensive responses point to a deepening credibility crisis within the ECI on several key fronts.

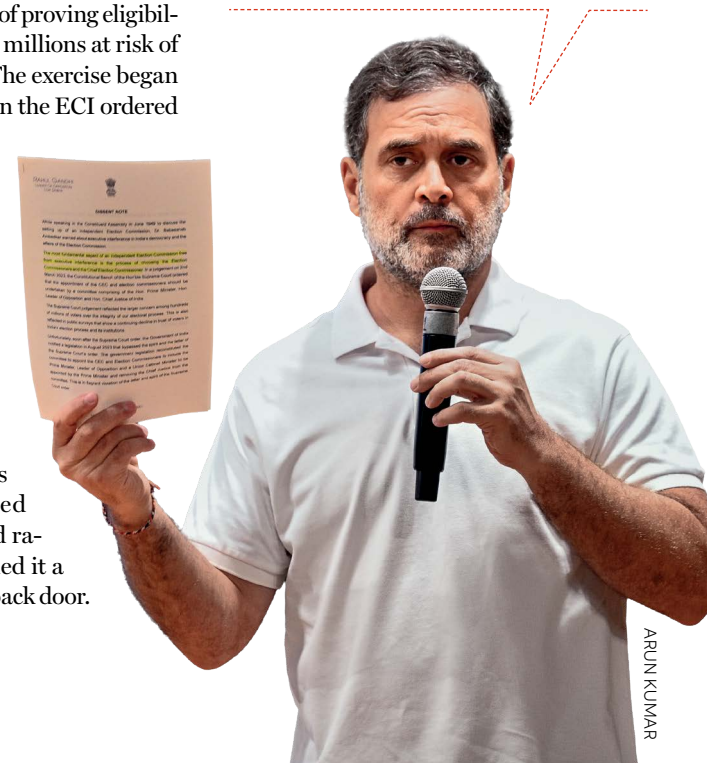
Crisis 1: The SIR's burden of proof

The first concern is the SIR itself, and whether a long-overdue clean-up of rolls has become a tool for shifting the burden of proving eligibility onto voters, leaving millions at risk of disenfranchisement. The exercise began on June 24, 2025, when the ECI ordered an intensive revision of Bihar's electoral rolls, the first since 2003, five months before the state election. Every elector had to submit a fresh enumeration form; those who could not be mapped to the 2003 roll had to produce one of 11 documents that initially excluded Aadhaar, voter ID and ration cards. Critics called it a citizenship test by the back door.

The SC later added Aadhaar as the 12th document, but specified it could serve as proof of identity, not of citizenship. On May 27 this year, it upheld the ECI's authority to conduct the SIR.

In West Bengal, nearly six months before polls in April this year, the ECI set in motion a process to link each elector to the previous intensive-revision roll. Those it could not link were marked "unmapped"; those it could link but with anomalies detected were flagged for "logical discrepancies". Around 13.6 million voters received such notices. The discrepancy categories grew from four to 11, including an age gap of under 15 years between a voter and a parent, more than six children linked to one parent, variations in how a parent's name was spelt, and women mapped to their father in an older roll but to their husband in the current one. None of these

> **"*Vote chori* is a crime against the Indian people and a direct attack on our Constitution. The BJP, RSS and EC who organised it have committed an act of treason"**
>
> **—RAHUL GANDHI**
> *Leader of Opposition, Lok Sabha*


ARUN KUMAR